Doctor of Ministry Program
TSM 50XX: Evangelism and Patristics – Fr. John Behr
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Evangelism in the Early Church

Introduction

The indisputable fact is that Christianity grew from a small group of disciples of an executed Jewish teacher in the region of Jerusalem to a major religious force in the Roman Empire in 300 years. In its growth, it contravened many of the established religious authorities during a time when religion was intimately tied in with the state, be it Roman or Jewish. *Religio* or state religion was a public act which connected the Roman state with the gods whereas *superstitio* was a private belief that was tolerated as long as it did not undermine authority.[1] This new belief both challenged the Roman *religio* and the local Jewish *superstitio*. By all logic, it should have been assimilated by Judaism, died out of lack of recruited membership, or even been destroyed by the Roman Empire. Yet somehow it grew and eventually flourished to become the religion of the Empire despite persecutions, slander and even demographic isolation. What was it about this Christianity that made it so attractive?

This question is at the heart of evangelism that is still relevant today. Was there some thing or some way that the early Church did that enabled this growth? Was there a model or method that the early Church utilized? Was there even a theology of evangelism that

[1] *Religio* can be defined as the public act of participation in the state cult. *Superstitio* was the private act of belief. In theory, all of the religions of the Empire could hold whatever *superstitio* as long as they participated in the *religio*. For a more comprehensive explanation, see Michael Green, *Evangelism in the Early Church*, (Grand Rapids, Eerdmans, 1970), 34-37.

was developed in these early years? Certainly, the New Testament bestows a solid foundation on the theology of evangelism and even some tantalizing clues on the process of evangelism in such passages as the so-called "Great Commission" in Matthew, the work of the early apostles as recorded in the Book of Acts and even in the Epistles of the Apostle Paul. The early Church patristic record also gives commentary on the life of the early Church as well as chronicling the theological development of the Church. But in reality, even the patristic record is scant with passages on the process of evangelism even through the insights into the developing theology, life and challenges of the early Church. But the question still remains as to what did those early apostles and leaders of the Church do to grow the Church? Was it a God inspired missionary zeal? Was it simply a matter of demographic growth? Was there an evangelistic strategy that was consciously and deliberately carried out by the Church? Or was it something else that feed into a world that seemed to be made ripe for the Christian message?

There have been a number of modern scholars who have attempted to unpack the answers to these questions. Most of them are quite polemical in that they came from a particular theological bent but all of them poured through the writings in an attempt to discover the answer. Adolph von Harnack was one of the first modernist scholars to examine in-depth the New Testament and early patristic record in an attempt to discover the cause of the growth. His famous book, The Mission and Expansion of Christianity in the First Three Centuries, set the standard for modern scholarship on the subject.[2] In the book, Harnack posed these same questions as he attempted to discover the reasons for such an explosive

[2] Adolph von Harnack, *The Mission and Expansion of Christianity in the First Three Centuries*, (Williams and Norgate, 1908) a translated by OCR, 2009.

growth. He concluded that the growth occurred because Christianity involved people of all strata of society (most notably the common people) and forged them into a loving and active community which addressed the needs of a communal existence. In addition, Christianity provided theological answers to the deep questions of existence, supplied an outlet to express those questions of life (and after life) through liturgical activities and through a membership in a community that bonded the believers together against a hostile world. He postulated that these were powerful forces that swept across the Empire and filled a void in a hostile and syncretic society. "From the very outset Christianity came forward with a spirit of universalism, by dint of which it laid hold of the entire life of man all its functions, throughout its heights and depths, in all its feelings, thoughts and actions. This guaranteed its triumph."[3] This universalism and depth enabled the Church to flourish in a hostile world because it was able to fill a need; a need to explain humanity's existence by binding people together. And as the message of the Gospel was changed from its Jewish roots toward a more "Hellenized" version, it was made more palatable, appealable, acceptable and explainable.

This issue was again taken up seventy years later by Michael Green in his modern classic, Evangelism in the Early Church.[4] He initially built upon Harnack's themes but came to a different conclusion which basically stated that the Church grew because of the clear Christocentric nature of the message was the appeal. The person of Jesus Christ embodied in his teachings and revolutionary worldview drew people to the message of salvation. The salvation found through Jesus was zealously presented in whatever forum

[3] Harnack, *Mission*, 406.
[4] Green, *Evangelism.*

that the ordinary Christian found themselves in and this zeal and message attracted followers. There was no grand plan or strategy, but rather ordinary Christians presenting themselves and their Faith. They did so out of a sense of gratitude for what they had been given, a sense of responsibility to share that gift, and a sense of concern for the implications of that gift.[5] But these ordinary Christians were living and dying extraordinary lives for the sake of the Gospel. This made the message about the Risen Christ a force because whole communities observed people willing to die for this belief. This passionate belief was a powerful witness that was also combined with a radical change in lifestyle. Christians simply lived and behaved differently and shared that in their own communities. Thus, evangelism was simply the lifeblood of the early Christians because they lived and died in their Faith. Green concluded, "In the first two centuries or so of the Church's existence we find many faults, much which dishonors the name they professed. But we also find an evangelistic zeal and effort, exerted by the whole broad spectrum of the Christian community to bring other people to the feet of their ascended Lord and into the fellowship of his willing servants."[6] With Green, it was simply Christians being Christians and there really was no measure of success or failure in evangelistic methods other than the Church growing. There was simply the life of Christian in a community which provided the growth and spread the Faith.

More recently scholars have taken up that particular point, growth through a community actualizing itself, as to the reason for the success of the early Church. Perhaps the explosive growth of the Church was not at all through a conscious evangelistic strategies

[5] See Green, *Evangelism*, chapter 9.
[6] Green, *Evangelism*, 280.

and methods (though they may have been hints of it), but rather it was through sociological and demographic shifts which the early Church community exploited. Rodney Stark's book, The Rise of Christianity, looked at the growth of the Church from this vantage point and postulated some critical discoveries.[7] Perhaps, he posed, the growth of the Church could be explained through demographic modeling and sociological paradigms. He claims, through the use of such modeling, that it could be demonstrated that Church grew because demographically it had to grow. Such factors as higher birth rates, higher survival rates during epidemics (which Christians served the sick thus making the survivors immune to the disease), freeing of the marginalized castes such as women and slaves, that led to a high growth rate as it spread throughout the known world. He combines this with modern data and theories on new church movements to verify the data on the early Church which he expostulated from primary sources. However, he acknowledges, as does Green, that the growth was not from the top down but rather because of "an intense community, able to generate 'invincible obstinacy'….yielding immense religious awards."[8] These rewards were incarnated in the growth of the Church despite the many factors which sought to limit or destroy it in the early years. But in the end, the Church grew as any other movement would have grown, even in contemporary times.

A Basic Understanding of the World

[7] Rodney Stark, *The Rise of Christianity: How the Obscure, Marginal Jesus Movement Became the Dominant Religious Force in the Western World in a Few Centuries*, (Princeton, Princeton University Press, 1997).
[8] Stark, *Rise*, 208.

Christianity exploded onto the world scene at a remarkable time. Rome controlled most of the known Western world and forged it into a massive empire. This control and influence spread throughout the Mediterranean region and truly all roads did lead to Rome. Rome had established a network of cities connected by roads and shipping lanes whereby trade flourished. Likewise, the political system, supported by the all powerful Roman army, maintained a tight control on the vast expanse of the Empire. In return for this tight control were just Roman laws and a stable government. The difference in cultures did not matter as long as all of them paid tribute to Rome. It really was a time of *Pax Romana*.

Despite this massive expense, there was also a tolerance of the many cultures. Rome subsumed many of the cultures and religions and was, in fact, quite tolerant of them as long as they did not challenge the power of Rome. As such it was perfectly acceptable for the pantheon of Roman gods to coexist with eastern mystical religions as well as the small monotheistic religion of Judaism. All of these were tolerated along side the different philosophical schools such Platonism, Stoicism and others as well as the cult of the Emperor. All of them were treated impartially. The only matter was how they related to the state. If it weakened the state or the "morality" of the people, then Rome took notice. "The Roman government was in practice tolerant of any cult provided it did not encourage sedation or weaken morality."[9] But if it did challenge the state and the stability of the government then Rome acted and acted swiftly.

Yet despite this tolerance, Rome perceived a threat posed by this new Jewish cult which

[9] Henry Chadwick, *The Early Church, London*, (UK, Penguin, 1967), 25.

proclaimed a criminal to be the "Son of God" and the Jewish Messiah? Why was it not seen as just another of the many cults in the Roman Empire competing for adherents? First was that the Christian were a people apart. They did not see the world in the same way as other cults. They threw off the Roman yoke not by actual sedation but by living and seeing the world in a different way. They would not participate in the god-emperor cult and offer sacrifices on his behalf. They refused to participate in a lifestyle they deemed immoral. They challenged the Roman rule by their very refusal to participate in the public rituals. People were expected to participate in the state cult and could still believe what they wanted in private. But when the Christian refused, it was seen as a political act against the state. This anti-social group even claimed the equality of men and women, free and slaves, even all races to be the same under God. It threatened the very structure of the Empire. When a fire swept through Rome in 64 AD, the Emperor Nero found them to be a convenient scapegoat for the woes of the Empire.[10]

In addition, there was the matter of the Jewish *ethnos*. These were a people who both lived in their homeland around Jerusalem but also were in Diaspora throughout the Empire. There was hardly a major city around the Mediterranean that did not have a Jewish population. These Jews were also quite different from those in Palestine. They were Hellenized and exposed to many different cultures and teachings. While they maintained a relationship with the Jews in Jerusalem, even sending funds and receiving teachers, they changed. They understood Greek philosophy and had learned to integrate in a wider culture. Some no longer spoke their language but were fluent in Greek. They even had their Scriptures translated into Greek so they could study it. They had

[10] Cornelius Tacitus, *The Annals* 15:44.

established a network which the early Church evangelists would exploit and follow even to the capital in Rome. It would be these same Jews who would be most open to this new Christian message and provide the funds to carry this message to the ends of the earth.

There was, however, another factor that affected the Empire. These Christians spoke of "loving one another", "eating the body and drinking the blood of Christ", and proclaimed only one God over all. Plus they met in secret, not in the open like other cults. This made the Christians targets for various accusations. An example, of such an accusation was found in Minucius Felix's *Ocatavius,*

> "And now, as wickeder things advance more fruitfully, and abandoned manners creep on day by day, those abominable shrines of an impious assembly are maturing themselves throughout the whole world. Assuredly this confederacy ought to be rooted out and execrated. They know one another by secret marks and insignia, and they love one another almost before they know one another; everywhere also there is mingled among them a certain religion of lust, and they call one another promiscuously brothers and sisters, that even a not unusual debauchery may by the intervention of that sacred name become incestuous: it is thus that their vain and senseless superstition glories in crimes."[11]

These accusations were blatant lies but they further pushed Christians to the margin. They just did not fit in with the rest of the Empire. While the ridiculousness of these charges was recognized, they still caused great confusion in the Empire. Pliny wrote when confronted with Christians,

> "They asserted, however, that the sum and substance of their fault or error had been that they were accustomed to meet on a fixed day before dawn and sing responsively a hymn to Christ as to a god, and to bind themselves by oath, not to some crime, but not to commit fraud, theft, or adultery, not falsify their trust, nor to refuse to return a trust when called upon to do so. When this was over, it was their custom to depart and to assemble again to partake of food--but ordinary and innocent food. Even this, they affirmed,

[11] Minucius Felix, *Octavius,* chapter 9.

> they had ceased to do after my edict by which, in accordance with your instructions, I had forbidden political associations. Accordingly, I judged it all the more necessary to find out what the truth was by torturing two female slaves who were called deaconesses. But I discovered nothing else but depraved, excessive superstition."[12]

These accusations would be defended by the early Christian writers as they explained not only the absurdity of the charges but that Christians were not as different as they were portrayed. For example, in the Epistle of Diognetus, the Mathetes, the author writes,

> "For the Christians are distinguished from other men neither by country, nor language, nor the customs which they observe. For they neither inhabit cities of their own, nor employ a peculiar form of speech, nor lead a life which is marked out by any singularity. The course of conduct which they follow has not been devised by any speculation or deliberation of inquisitive men; nor do they, like some, proclaim themselves the advocates of any merely human doctrines. But, inhabiting Greek as well as barbarian cities, according as the lot of each of them has determined, and following the customs of the natives in respect to clothing, food, and the rest of their ordinary conduct, they display to us their wonderful and confessedly striking method of life. They dwell in their own countries, but simply as sojourners. As citizens, they share in all things with others, and yet endure all things as if foreigners. Every foreign land is to them as their native country, and every land of their birth as a land of strangers. They marry, as do all [others]; they beget children; but they do not destroy their offspring. They have a common table, but not a common bed. They are in the flesh, but they do not live after the flesh. They pass their days on earth, but they are citizens of heaven. They obey the prescribed laws, and at the same time surpass the laws by their lives. They love all men, and are persecuted by all. They are unknown and condemned; they are put to death, and restored to life. They are poor, yet make many rich; they are in lack of all things, and yet abound in all; they are dishonored, and yet in their very dishonor are glorified. They are evil spoken of, and yet are justified; they are reviled, and bless; they are insulted, and repay the insult with honor; they do good, yet are punished as evil-doers. When punished, they rejoice as if quickened into life; they are assailed by the Jews as foreigners, and are persecuted by the Greeks; yet those who hate them are unable to assign any reason for their hatred."[13]

[12] Pliny the Younger, *Letter to Trajan*, 10:96-97.
[13] Mathetes, *Epistle to Diognetus*, chapter 5.

Even though the Christians were different in lifestyle and worldview, they were people of the Empire. Some, like the Apostle Paul and Ignatius, even used their citizenship to appeal to Rome for trial so that they could further witness about Christianity. In the end, the Christian people would go through a series of persecutions and lapses, acceptance and dismissal, charges and counter-charges until it would finally, through the Edict of Milan in 313 AD, receive legitimacy. And even then, the challenges of orthodoxy and heresy would continue.

The Subject of Evangelism: Jesus Christ

Despite these challenges, the subject of all the evangelistic efforts by the early Church remained consistent. The early Christians did not go about preaching and teaching some general eschatological radical change. Otherwise the message would be as any other of the many cult religions that were extent at the time. Rather it was put in context; instead, they preached about a person. This person was Jesus. He was the subject and the message. It was by understanding Jesus and his mission that there came clarity as to what was being preached. The Christians claimed that Jesus was the son of God, the fulfillment of the hope of Israel and the long awaited Messiah. He brought about a change in understanding the relationship between God and man and that radical repentance was possible. It was only by understanding who Jesus was and what he did that one began to understand the Gospel that was being preached. Origen wrote in his commentary on John,

> "Now what the Gospels say is to be regarded in the light of promises of good things; and we must say that the good things the Apostles announce in this Gospel are simply Jesus. One good thing which they are said to

> announce is the resurrection; but the resurrection is in a manner Jesus, for Jesus says: "I am the resurrection." Jesus preaches to the poor those things which are laid up for the saints, calling them to the divine promises."[14]

Thus it was Jesus the Christ who not only preached a new life in God but even a new death. Death was the common factor that all people shared and here was a person who stated that even death was not the end. It was possible to die and yet to live in God. The world did not seem so frightening when death itself could be overcome.

These critical thoughts were found throughout the Scriptures, which eventually included these stories about Jesus as a New Testament, were radical ideas. That there was a person Jesus Christ, the Son of God, who had come into the world to save mankind. He died and rose from the dead and opened the door for all mankind to be reconnected with God. This was a radical message from a condemned criminal who had followers who preached and taught in his name. This person of Jesus Christ was the message. In 1 Corinthians 1:18-24, Paul teaches that to those who do not understand or look for other ways of understanding, this Christ is "foolishness". But to those who seek him, "Christ the power of God and the wisdom of God." In effect, the Christian were telling the rest of the world that they (non-Christians) were at best fools and possibly deluded. The foundation of the Empire was challenged and the entire Jewish faith was being overturned and a group of people were prepared to suffer and die for this message.

In terms of evangelism, the Risen Christ is the message that was proclaimed by the early Church evangelists. It was believed that through preaching about him, that people would come to a greater understanding of Christianity. "The early Church did not understand mission as a merely human action done in response to the good things God has done,

[14] Origen, *Commentary on John*, book 1:10.

Mission was perceived christologically – as God acting for the salvation of fallen mankind, but God acting only in union with mankind."[15] Harnack even identified three stages on the mission preaching about Christ in the early Church which illustrates this point.[16] The first stage was basically that the kingdom of God is at hand and it is time to repent. This message would have resounded with the early Jews who were looking for that kingdom. They expected an earthly kingdom as expressed in their dissatisfaction with Christ in his entrance into Jerusalem. They expected an earthly king to overthrow the Romans and when they realized that this was not to be, quickly turned against him. "Mission…is to proclaim the imminence of the kingdom of God, to awaken a sense to the other world – the city God has prepared for us – which is our homeland, where we truly belong."[17] But as the Gospels consistently set out, from John the Baptist to the first teachings of Christ, the message was repentance as the time had now come.[18] This same message was brought forth by the early Church even after His death and resurrection as a message of His imminent second coming.

The second stage of preaching, according to Harnack, is that Jesus is the messiah. For example, the Evangelist Mathew stressed this point throughout his Gospel account by pointing to Jesus' lineage, his fulfillment of the prophecies, his powers of healing and teaching. The Gospel writer even went so far as to recount God himself speaking and stating that Jesus is "His beloved Son in whom He is well pleased."[19] To the Jews this

[15] William C. Weinrich, "Evangelism in the Early Church" *Concordia Theological Review* 45, no 1-2 (1981), 62.
[16] Harnack, *Expansion*, 76
[17] Andrew Louth, "The Church's Mission: Patristic Presuppostions" *Greek Orthodox Theological Review* 44, no 1-4 (1999), 655.
[18] See Matthew 3:1-2 and then refer to Matthew 4:17 or Mark 1:4 and then refer to Mark 1:14-15.
[19] Matthew 3:13-17, Mark 1:9-11, Luke 3:21-22, and John 1:29-33 record the baptism of Christ. Other events such as the Transfiguration and Crucifixion also record a similar announcement.

was blasphemy and to the Gentiles it was foolishness. Yet it was effective. No where had a religion claimed not just a God taking human form but a salvific God incarnated in a person. The early Christians would use this message as a proof of the divinity and unique nature of Christ and it resonated. He had come to save the Jews as was the promise and this salvation even went to the Gentiles. The entire world was to be saved and the message was no confined to one small ethnic group but to an entire creation.

The final stage according to Harnack was an interpretation of the Old Testament, as a fulfillment of in Jesus Christ that changed the moral principles of the Old Testament. In other words, Christ turned the law upside-down and showed that is was not enough to follow the law, but to actually internalize it and change one's life. For example, the commentary of Christ in Matthew 5 demonstrates that it is not just about following the law but to actually act in a way that demonstrates a change: not just an eye for an eye but to forgive those who do harm, to not commit adultery in body but also in the mind as well. These changes bring about a new person who lives in a way that is radically different then those around them. This message that is preached actually challenges normal conventions and puts a Christian at odds with the world and not just with the laws of the Old Testament. It was a moral code that contravened established norms both in pagan and Jewish society. This was critical in a time when so many other pagan religions actually encouraged what was deemed immoral or unethical behavior. Christians were different, even to those who thought they were acting ethically and morally.

So through these identifiable messages, the Christian message was presented. Some resonated stronger with different groups. Jews would listen about the long awaited

messiah but this would not be as strong for the Gentile. Instead such elements as radical repentance would have a greater appeal. In the end, the message was still centered on Jesus.

Common Points of Understanding

While all three major authors may differ on the various nuances of evangelism in the early Church, there are some commonalities that the New Testament and patristic record can affirm. First, evangelism in the early Church was clearly and definitively centered around the person of Jesus Christ. He was the message and he was what was preached. The early Christians witnessed to the Risen Lord Jesus Christ at every opportunity no matter the forum. If was serving the poor, it was done in the name of Christ. If it was debating the pagan philosophers, then it was done to present the theology of Christianity. If the Christian was persecuted even to death, they accepted it as a witness to the truth of Christ. In all things and in all ways, Christ was the message. The Apostle Paul chastised the Corinthians because they were looking at other people who brought the Christian message when, in fact, the message was about Christ Himself.[20] While the early Church Fathers developed and refined that theology, eventually leading to the need for a fixed and closed canon, it was consistently centered around understanding who and what this person Jesus was and how His Church was best served. While early heresies sought to change the developing theology, the early Church maintained a consistency of the message.

[20] 1 Corinthians 1:1-31.

Second, evangelism was part of a communal experience of the Church. There were not just individual believers, though they may have acted individually, but rather they were part of a Church community as members of the Body of Christ. Evangelism drew new people into full membership into the Body of Christ no matter their background, ethnicity or social standing. This was done by various people in various positions in the Church, but they all became members of the Body of Christ.[21] That communal experience was experienced not only socially but also sacramentally through the participation in the Eucharistic fellowship. By being part of that *koinonia*, they gathered together as a body to worship and partake of the Eucharist and to serve one another. It was not simply as some social club or mutual aid society but it was in keeping with the command of Christ Himself to gather and commune. This passage in the Acts of the Apostles demonstrates such a *koinonia*.

> "And they continued steadfastly in the apostles' doctrine and fellowship, in the breaking of bread, and in prayers. Then fear came upon every soul, and many wonders and signs were done through the apostles. Now all who believed were together, and had all things in common, and sold their possessions and goods, and divided them among all, as anyone had need. So continuing daily with one accord in the temple, and breaking bread from house to house, they ate their food with gladness and simplicity of heart, praising God and having favor with all the people. And the Lord added to the church daily those who were being saved." (Acts 2:42-47)

Even despite the efforts by non-Christians to discredit or to outright prevent these meetings, the early Christians preserved and grew. Rather then being weakened by such obstacles, they served to strengthen their Faith and continued to draw new people into the Body of Christ. As Justin Martyr wrote in his letter to the pagan Trypho,

> "For it is plain that, though beheaded, and crucified, and thrown to wild beasts, and chains, and fire, and all other kinds of torture, we do not give

[21] See 1 Corinthians 12:1-30.

> up our confession; but the more such things happen, the more do others and in larger numbers become faithful, and worshippers of God through the name of Jesus. For Just as if one should cut away the fruit-bearing parts of a vine, it grows up again, and yields other branches flourishing and fruitful; even so the same thing happens with us. For the vine planted by God and Christ the Savior is His people."[22]

The early Church grew because the Body of Christ served to be that repository for faithful witness and a safe haven against a hostile world. People were willing to risk everything to be part of that Body. They became brothers and sisters in Christ.

Third, evangelism was not necessarily a strategy but rather a way of living. It was a Christian's vocation to present the Gospel but it was also through their faithful lifestyle that the Gospel was incarnated. They lived an honorable life and dealt with others with compassion and love. A Christian threw off pagan views, lifestyles and even a certain morality when they took on the yoke of Christ. They lived a life of purity and high ethics. Justin Martyr wrote,

> "'And let your good works shine before men, that they, seeing them, may glorify your Father which is in heaven.' For we ought not to strive; neither has He desired us to be imitators of wicked men, but He has exhorted us to lead all men, by patience and gentleness, from shame and the love of evil. And this indeed is proved in the case of many who once were of your way of thinking, but have changed their violent and tyrannical disposition, being overcome either by the constancy which they have witnessed in their neighbors' lives, or by the extraordinary forbearance they have observed in their fellow-travelers when defrauded, or by the honesty of those with whom they have transacted business."[23]

A Christian was a moral and ethical person and this was incredibly attractive.

[22] Justin Martyr, *Letter to Trypho*, 110.
[23] Justin Martyr, *1st Apology*, 16.

Even when confronted with injustice and cruelty, a Christian "turned the other cheek." They took seriously the commands of Christ and lived accordingly. Now certainly this may be a romantic view of the early Christians as there were those who fell away or were not as faithful (hence the need for the development of such rites as Confession) but overall a Christian was a different creature. As Ignatius of Antioch wrote to the Ephesians:

> "And pray without ceasing in behalf of other men. For there is in them hope of repentance that they may attain to God. See, then, that they be instructed by your works, if in no other way. Be meek in response to their wrath, humble in opposition to their boasting: to their blasphemies return your prayers; in contrast to their error, be steadfast in the faith; and for their cruelty, manifest your gentleness. While we take care not to imitate their conduct, let us be found their brethren in all true kindness; and let us seek to be followers of the Lord (who ever more unjustly treated, more destitute, more condemned?), that so no plant of the devil may be found in you, but you may remain in all holiness and sobriety in Jesus Christ, both with respect to the flesh and spirit."[24]

Thus, Christians evangelized because that is what Christians did, they presented the Gospel of Jesus Christ in their life. They evangelized because they felt a pride and love in the Gospel message. They wanted to share the good news through a joy in being a Christian. Furthermore, they did so out of obedience to the great commandment to make disciples of the world. It was not a message they felt compelled to keep to themselves. While there may have been some confusion as to whom that message should go to, which was resolved very early in the Church, that desire spoke very loudly to the message which they shared with others.[25] Being a Christian meant to share the message. "The rapid expansion of the Christian faith is itself a testimony to the fact that evangelism was

[24] Ignatius, *On Ephesians* ,10

[25] The question of whether Gentiles needed to be received as Jews before becoming Christians (as well as other critical issues of the mission to the Gentiles) was resolved in the Jerusalem Council as recounted in Acts 15 and Galatians 2.

the task of every Christian….Witnessing the Gospel was not the work just of professional, full-time missionaries. Because all Christians were baptized into Christ, all Christians were taken up in the missionary endeavor."[26]

Forth, being a Christian meant a fundamental and perhaps radical change in worldview. Christian lived differently then those around them; sometimes in harmony with society and sometimes in direct conflict with society. But essentially they were a new and different people. They were a monotheistic people (not necessarily unusual at the time) with a different view of creation, sin, redemption. They believed in an active God who was incarnate and came into the world. They preached a God who took human flesh to redeem His creation. Their God was not a distant God but one who was with them, even if physically he was not. Early Christian theologians wrote extensively on these views and often compared them to the extent pagan philosophies. Time and again they defended and refined their arguments not only against the pagans but also a Judaism that they claimed to have grown. The early Christians had to convince not only the potential Jewish converts of the adherence and fulfillment of the Jewish Scriptures but also the pagan philosophers of the unassailable rationale for their beliefs. When Tertullian posed the question, "What has Athens have to do with Jerusalem?" or "the academy with the Church?", he was seeking to understand both the incompatibility as well as the similarities.[27]

The early Church fathers wrote extensive and sophisticated theological explanations and admonitions. Often these were in response to heretical challenges but they were also part

[26] Weinrich, *Evangelism*, 65.
[27] Tertullian, *The Prescription Against Heretics*, 7.

of developing a theology of difficult questions on the nature of Christ, the theology of the Trinity, soteriology, and even ecclesiology. While this may seem to be very high thinking, it was in fact quite practical in application. People needed to understand what constituted "right belief" when there were many around who preached a different Christ or a different Church. They needed to understand what was the proper canon of Scripture, the proper interpretation of Faith and how that was to be lived out. The early Church was challenged by a host of heresies, in fact the list is extensive and covers a wide spectrum of interpretations. And this quest for right belief shaped what the Christian Faith and how they were to live out their Faith. Added to this was persecution and marginalization so that it was shocking that any unity and consistency was achieved. This was why such catechisms were developed in order to instruct those coming into the Faith as well as to instruct those in the Faith. Some were of a more simple nature such as the Didache or the Shepherd of Hermes which were practical in application. Other reached a level of intense theological sophistication such as the Catechetical Lectures of Cyril of Jerusalem. Even the vita of the saints, the accounts of the martyrdoms and the histories of the Church served to educate and enlighten. As the Martyrdom of Polycarp states in its introduction,

> "We have written unto you, brethren, the things respecting those who were martyred, and concerning the blessed Polycarp, who made the persecution to cease, having as it were set his seal to it by his testimony. For almost all the things that went before happened in order that the Lord might show us from above the testimony that is according to the gospel; for he endured to be betrayed, even as did the Lord, that we might become imitators of him, not as considering the things that concern ourselves only, but also the things that concern our neighbors; for it belongs to true and firm love not only to desire to be saved itself, but also that all the brethren should be saved." [28]

Finally, evangelism in the early Church used what had come before. It used the

[28] Unknown, *Martyrdom of Polycarp*, 1:1-2.

Scriptures and in some cases the rituals of Judaism though redefined in a Christian context. It was heir to centuries of Jewish thought and rituals which were now contextualized as Christian. This was not without conflict and it would take centuries for this to be understood. But early Christians remained very tied to their Jewish roots even in practical ways. There were established network of Jewish communities. These networks provided money, shelter and an audience for a growing church.

But the early Christian Church even used the Roman world to their advantage. They used the network of Roman cities and transport, legal systems and government. It even used the pagan philosophy to assist in defining and defending itself. Therefore, the change that came through Christianity was a change but one that could be understood by a wide spectrum of society. So when Christianity exploded onto the scene, it was because it offered an appeal to a wide spectrum of society that perhaps were seeking answers to deeply important questions of life and death. For whatever the reason, these answers were lacking or had become stale in the other existing religions or philosophies. It filled a void that was made ready for its coming.

The Early Church Spreads

The rapid expansion of Christianity had to be accomplished by people. There had to be emissaries who would carry the Gospel message to the world. While the first evangelists concentrated in Jerusalem and its immediate locale, they also began to move into the surrounding regions. This brought them in contact with the gentile world and as they began to move farther out, they preached this message to differing regions in their

expanding world. They did not limit their message to just Jews but used Jesus Himself as an example by preaching to non-Jews. Jesus preached to the Samaritan woman (John 4:3-42), healed the daughter of the Canaanite woman (Matt 15:22-28) and even the servant of the Roman centurion (Luke 7:1-10, Matt 8:5-13) Clearly, Jesus' message was to the entire world as He Himself had instructed his disciples in the Great Commission.

The early followers of Christ also followed the same pattern. They brought the Gospel message to whomever desired to hear it and to whatever place they were brought. The Apostle Peter went to the Gentiles as recounted in Acts and, of course the Apostle Paul went throughout the Mediterranean region to preach the Gospel. While this was not without controversy, the resolution of this issue was a critical turning point in the growth of the Church. It would not and could not remain a Jewish cult if it was to expand. While, the Apostle Paul was rejected in Athens, the home of pagan philosophy (Acts 17), his successors would eventually prevail in those same regions. Even after the death of the first apostles, the Church continued to send missionaries throughout the known world. Eusebius records in his Ecclesiastical History that the early apostles and disciples dispersed throughout the world to preach the Gospel.

> "Such was the condition of the Jews. Meanwhile the holy apostles and disciples of our Savior were dispersed throughout the world. Parthia, according to tradition, was allotted to Thomas as his field of labor, Scythia to Andrew, and Asia to John, who, after he had lived some time there, died at Ephesus. Peter appears to have preached in Pontus, Galatia, Bithynia, Cappadocia, and Asia to the Jews of the dispersion. And at last, having come to Rome, he was crucified head-downwards; for he had requested that he might suffer in this way. What do we need to say concerning Paul, who preached the Gospel of Christ from Jerusalem to Illyricum, and afterwards suffered martyrdom in Rome under Nero?"[29]

[29] Eusebius, *Ecclesiastical History*, 3:1-2.

All of the early apostles and disciples were sent outward throughout the world. This would continue as the Church grew, outstripping its Jerusalem roots and becoming a universal religion. The early Church consciously and carefully spread outward.

The way they spread outward was to utilize what was already in existence, mainly a network of communities in the Jewish Diaspora. These "Hellenized Jews" existed throughout the know world, even in the political capital of Rome. The Apostle Paul clearly followed these paths in his missionary journeys. And as each came to a community, they were received as so many other teachers/leaders were received from Jerusalem, the spiritual homeland of the dispersed people. Stark postulated that this network was the key to spreading Christianity. "In all the major centers of the empire were substantial settlements of Diasporan Jews *who were accustomed to receiving teachers from Jerusalem.*"[30] Furthermore, it would be a natural audience for the message as these Jews would be open to a messiah coming from Palestine, a backwater of the Empire. In addition, they would be familiar with the Old Testament that was referenced in the Gospels. What is clear that these Jewish communities were the leaven for the early Christian communities. The early missionaries did their public teaching in the synagogues and most of the early converts were Hellenized Jews.

As the early Church expanded, it was natural to assume that the pool of potential converts also had to expand outward. There were only so many dispersed Jews to draw from and with the opening to the Gentile world, more of the converts were from other *ethnos*. In addition, as local communities were established, the local leaders were raised from within these communities and they had ties to the local people. Rather then continuing to look

[30] Stark, *Rise*, 62

inward, the Church began to expand outward. This expansion was all the difference in the growth of the Church.

The Early Church Evangelists

But who were these early missionaries and what do they reveal about evangelism? By putting flesh on those who evangelized, perhaps the methodology could be further revealed. The New Testament and early patristic record recounts eight different groups that were drawn form all stratum of society. They were not limited to one such group, but rather there were many different people were involved in transmitting the Good News. Christianity was not exclusive in this way but rather inclusive of all: free and slave, Jew and gentile, male and female, educated philosopher and simple fishermen were all part of the evangelistic effort. They all had the zeal and love for Christ. "One of the most striking features in evangelism in the early days was the people who engaged in it. Communicating the Faith was not regarded as the preserve of the very zealous or of the officially designated evangelist, evangelism was the prerogative of every Church member….The ordinary people of the Church saw it as their job: Christianity was supremely a lay movement, spread by informal missionaries. The clergy of the Church saw it as their responsibility too: bishops and presbyters, together with doctors of the Church…saw the propagation of the Gospel as their prime concern."[31] So, as such, many different groups with different skill sets were involved in spreading the Gospel as the Apostle Paul recounts in the Epistle to the Ephesians, Chapter 4 outlining all the different gifts of the Holy Spirit. All of them had the responsibility of spreading the Gospel.

[31] Green, *Evangelism*, 274.

The first group was the most obvious, the immediate apostles and disciples of Christ. They went forth into the world as written in Acts 1:8, preaching the Gospel. The *vitas* of these apostles, even if apocryphal, are remarkable in the breadth of their recounted travels. For example, Peter and Paul were martyred in Rome, Thomas travelled to India, Lazarus ended up in Cyprus and so on. Of course, much is documented about the travels of Peter and Paul but the other original disciples also, according to tradition, went throughout the known world. There they established communities and trained local leaders. These leaders were varied such Lydia and Timothy but they also left disciples of their own. For example, Polycarp of Smyrna was reputed to be a disciple of the Evangelist John. In some cases, the apostles stayed in a region, such as James being the first bishop of Jerusalem, and maintained the Church. In any case, the early apostles and disciples were critical to spreading the Church. They collected money for the local Church, brought with them early encyclical letters, exercised powers in organization and discipline, and formed the early Church council which dealt with the many issues that arose.[32] In short, they were the early Church organization. In the Book Two of Eusebius' Ecclesiastical History, the author recounts the travels of the early apostles and disciples and how they established communities. For example, the Apostle Mark established the Christian community in Egypt which flourished, "And they say that this Mark was the first that was sent to Egypt, and that he proclaimed the Gospel which he had written, and first established churches in Alexandria. And the multitude of believers, both men and women, that were collected there at the very outset, and lived lives of the most philosophical and excessive asceticism, was so great, that Philo thought it worth while to describe their pursuits, their meetings, their entertainments, and their whole manner of

[32] See Harnack, *Expansion*, section 17 p 261 for more detail.

life."[33] Thus it was clear that by Eusebius' time in the late 3rd century, there was an established record of the missionary work of the early apostles.

The next group was the early missionaries, usually wandering from city to city, region to region. Acts 8:4 as well as Acts 14:26-27 hints at their existence but the early Church document The Didache discusses them up in greater detail. While much of the document is a morality lesson and an explanation of early Christian rituals, there is a section which gives instruction on receiving wandering missionaries and discerning their authenticity. These wandering missionaries, it seemed, were not connected with any particular community, however, rather communities were required to receive these missionaries and to "honor him as the Lord."[34] In return. these same missionaries had certain restrictions imposed on them to demonstrate that they were genuine. The community had to discern that they were teaching the same Gospel, they were to support them in food but not financially, allow them to stay for up to two days, and listen carefully to what they teach.[35] So clearly there were many false missionaries as the community was warned several times to discern true from false prophets.

These wandering missionaries seem to be present into the 3rd century. Origen writes in Contra Celsum about the same issues of wandering missionaries. "Christians do not neglect, as far as in them lies, to take measures to disseminate their doctrine throughout the whole world. Some of them, accordingly, have made it their business to itinerate not only through cities, but even villages and country houses, that they might make converts

[33] Eusebius *EH*, book 2, chapter 16.
[34] Unknown, *The Didache*, 4:1, 11:5.
[35] *Didache*, 11.

to God."[36] But he also uses these people as proof to the growth and diversity of the growing Christian community. While these wandering missionaries may have continued, it seems that later history does not record them as much and perhaps the wandering missionary was replaced by established communities with their own leaders, who in turn may have sent out others to preach the Gospel.

The next category would precisely be these local leaders that transitioned from wandering missionaries to local authorities. The New Testament did speak of these early leaders in the two tiered system of bishops/presbyters and deacons (1 Timothy 3 and Titus 1:5-9). These were to be men above reproach who met certain marital and moral qualifications in order to lead the community. The Didache also echoes those same qualifications "Appoint, therefore, for yourselves, bishops and deacons worthy of the Lord, men meek, and not lovers of money, and truthful and proved; for they also render to you the service of prophets and teachers. Therefore do not despise them, for they are your honored ones, together with the prophets and teachers."[37] In Clement's Epistle to the Corinthians, it seems that the transition from the wandering preacher to the local leaders was becoming more common.

> "The apostles have preached the Gospel to us from the Lord Jesus Christ; Jesus Christ was sent forth by God, and the apostles by Christ. Both these appointments, then, were made in an orderly way, according to the will of God. Having therefore received their orders, and being fully assured by the resurrection of our Lord Jesus Christ, and established in the word of God, with full assurance of the Holy Ghost, they went forth proclaiming that the kingdom of God was at hand. And thus preaching through countries and cities, they appointed the first-fruits, having first proved them by the Spirit, to be bishops and deacons of those who should afterwards believe. Nor was this any new thing, since indeed many ages

[36] Origen, *Contra Celsum,* book 3,chapter 9.
[37] *Didache*, 15.1-4.

> before it was written concerning bishops and deacons. For thus says the Scripture a certain place, "I will appoint their bishops in righteousness, and their deacons in faith."[38]

It also seems in Clement's Epistle that the purpose of the leaders was not just preaching but being the sacramental leaders for the community.[39] And as these communities grew, the responsibilities and division of labor developed as well. Ignatius of Antioch wrote of the grace being gathered around the person of the bishop and the need for honorable men.

> "Since therefore I have, in the persons before mentioned, beheld the whole multitude of you in faith and love, I exhort you to study to do all things with a divine harmony, while your bishop presides in the place of God, and your presbyters in the place of the assembly of the apostles, along with your deacons, who are most dear to me, and are entrusted with the ministry of Jesus Christ…Let nothing exist among you that may divide you ; but be ye united with your bishop, and those that preside over you, as a type and evidence of your immortality."[40]

This system continued to develop until by 325 and the First Ecumenical Council, there was a need to codify many of the requirements and duties of the clergy.

Regardless of the evolution of the clergy caste, it was clear that so many of the responsibilities of preaching, teaching and serving the people was placed in their hands. "If we look then look at the Church as it has existed at the end of the second century, if not earlier, then we see a church in which any specifically missionary ministry – that of the apostles and prophets – has died out, and the formal ministry of the Church has been replaced by an essentially pastoral ministry – of bishops, priests and deacons."[41] How that transition happened is not so clear but even when Irenaeus and Cyprian were outlining the theology of the episcopacy, the clear leadership of the community had

[38] Clement, *First Epistle to Corinthians*, 42. 1-5.
[39] Clement *First*, 40.
[40] Ignatius, *Epistle to Magnesians*, 6:1-2.
[41] Louth, *Patristic*, 651.

already been transferred. The bishop became responsible for the local community as the successor of the apostles and not the wandering missionary. Even then there was a strong need for establishing clear criteria of leadership, a clear canon of scripture and strong orthodox sense of theology. These were to reside in the bishop who regulated the priests and deacons. They became responsible for establishing the communities and preaching the Gospel.

This need for a clear theology led to the next category, that of the philosopher/theologian. The Apostle Paul speaks of the ministries in a community in his First Epistle to the Corinthians (I Cor 12). Among the top is the teacher seen on par with preachers and apostles. The teacher was to instruct those in the faith. It would seem that later in the early Church, the teacher would be classically trained and able to speak fluently in the language of the different philosophical schools. Justin Martyr claimed to be trained in Stoicism.[42] Clement of Alexandria was supposedly trained in Athens.[43] Others were trained by in catechetical schools established by other Church Fathers. Ireneaus was trained by Polycarp and Origen was trained by Clement. Thus, many of the early patristic writings were apologies of the Christian Faith in which a particular theologian would discuss certain aspects of Christianity in the language of those philosophical schools. Some of the early converts to the Church came through these schools. Others were trained as Church leaders and came to a deep knowledge of the Faith through their service such as Athanasius and Cyprian. "They grew the Faith not by asserting an insoluble conflict, a fundamental incompatibility between Hellenism and the Christian

[42] Justin, *Trypho*, chapter 2:8.
[43] Kallistos Ware, "The Light that Enlightens Everyone: The Knowledge of God Among Non-Christians According to the Greek Fathers and St. Innocent" *Greek Orthodox Theological Review* 44, no 1-4 (1999) 560.

message, but by indicating their possible convergence."[44] These leaders would utilize that training to discuss such difficult subjects as the nature of the Trinity and the nature of Christ.

These theologians became even more critical when the Church was confronted with such heretical movements as Gnosticism. In fact, there is recorded over twenty different heretical movements in the first century alone. These leaders were responsible for addressing these and leading the Church. Eventually, such movements would necessitate the establishment of an accepted and universal creed of belief and a canon of scripture and law in order to ensure the right teaching of the Faith. And without this right teaching, it could be reasonably assumed that Christianity would have divided, withered and died.

A further group that evangelized was the great martyrs and confessors of the early Church. Martyrdom was at its core from the very beginning of the Church; St. Stephen being stoned to death by the Jewish authorities in Acts 6-7. Each of the apostles, with the exception of John, would die a martyr's death. Event the earliest Christians suffered martyrdom including some of the great leaders of the Church such as Polycarp, whose account of martyrdom became a great witness in defense of Christianity. In The Martyrdom of Polycarp, there is a consistent reference to how his death was in accordance with the Gospel and in imitation of Christ. These early martyrs used the occasion of their martyrdom as a witness to the Faith. Justin Martyr believed so strongly in his faith, "I hope that, if I endure these things, I shall have His gifts. For I know that, to

[44] Ware, *Light*, 559.

all who have thus lived, there abides the divine favor until the completion of the whole world."[45]

These martyrdoms were, in effect, great witnesses to the truth of Christianity. Each of the stories recount how people seeing the consistency of the Christian even unto death could not help but admire them. Some even converted after witnessing such deaths. As Tertullian recounts, "the blood of the Christians is seed for the Church."[46] This was because the witness of the martyrdom enabled them to question the authorities. They saw a righteous person being condemned for being righteous and thus this led to further exploring of Christianity. So rather suppressing and ending the Christian movement, martyrdom enabled it to grow. Or as Harnack succinctly states, "the martyrs showed success."[47]

The legitimization of Christianity and the decrease in martyrdom may have led to the development of the next group of early missionaries, that of the ascetic/monastic. While the exact timing of the rise of the monastic movement is open to discussion, it is clear that as the persecutions dissipated, the monastic movement grew; perhaps as an alternative or "personal" martyrdom. There was a history of asceticism that was in Judaism, perhaps developed by the Essene movement. In this same vein, people such as John the Baptist arose, leading people towards a deeper expression of Faith. In some cases, whole communities grew around these ascetical movements or they became a gathering point for people seeking deeper knowledge, faith and even healing. The apocryphal Life of Paul and Thecla speak of a young woman, upon hearing Paul's

[45] Justin, *Fathers*, chapter 4.
[46] Tertullian, *The Apology*, chapter 50.
[47] Harnack, *Expansion*, 289.

discourse on virginity, leaves everything in order live an ascetical life and is even presented as an equal to an apostle.[48] These communities continued to develop and by the time of Anthony of Egypt, there seems to be an established ascetical movement. For example, in the Life of St. Anthony by Athanasius, there is reference to people leaving the city to dwell in the vicinity to dedicate themselves to solitude and prayer. "For there were not yet so many monasteries in Egypt, and no monk at all knew of the distant desert; but all who wished to give heed to themselves practiced the discipline in solitude near their own village."[49] It became so acute that the devil was reported to have cursed St. Anthony, "I have no longer a place, arrow or town of my own. The Christians have settled everywhere; even the desert has been crowded with monks."[50] These early ascetics were already establishing themselves in remote locales.

However, this ascetical movement also led to a rise in what would later be deemed, heretical movements. Certain leaders would arise who preached a more "purified" level of Christianity. The various Gnostic movements are an example of this, each with their own leaders, teachings and followers. Montanism and Donatism would arise through such movements as well. These would come in conflict with orthodox Christianity and divide the people. Other movements become strong with charismatic leader who would gain major Christian leaders. Tertullian was a classic example of a major leader who through various reason left orthodoxy to follow Montanism. Origen would become a strict adherent of such a "purified" movement that he eventually castrated himself.

[48] Unknown, *Life of Paul and Thecla*. Also see Louth, *Patristic*, 653.
[49] Athanasius, *Life of St. Anthony*, chapter 3.
[50] Athanasius, *Life*, chapter 41.

Nonetheless, these burgeoning ascetical movements would eventually become a powerful force in Christianity or as it stated in the Life of St. Anthony, "The desert was turned into a city by monks."[51] Monasteries would be established which produced great theologians and leaders for the Church. The ranks of the clergy, especially the episcopacy, would be drawn from the ranks of the monastics. Communities would be established around the great monasteries, even monasteries themselves would leave the wilderness and be established in urban centers. "Only with the rise of monasticism did unpopulated and desert places hold the interest of leading and learned Christians, not usually for missionary purposes, although monasteries and even the hermits often did become the means of Christianizing new areas."[52] Monastics would become the missionaries that would carry the Christian message to many of the more remote regions of the Empire; freed from worldly cares and desires.

The next group that evangelized were the local leaders of the local communities. Prior to the establishment and codification of the hierarchical offices, many of the communities were led by local Christians who often gathered in "house" churches. They were drawn from those who were especially zealous and were appointed by other missionaries to led the community. The New Testament mentions some of their names because they were considered important to be addressed. And they also may have been sent to different communities to provide leadership. Many of the names are familiar such as Paul, Barnabas, Timothy, Silas, who were specically sent out.[53] Some were local leaders.

[51] Athanasius, *Life*, chapter 14.
[52] Winston Crum, "The Mission of the Church in the New Testament and Patristic Writings" *Missiology* XII, no 1 (January 1984) 84.
[53] Acts 13:1-4 presents Barnabas and Saul (Paul). Acts 14:26-28 report on their experience in Antioch. Acts 15:40 records Paul and Silas being sent on mission. Acts 16:1-3 recounts Paul recruiting Timothy.

Apollos seems to be a local leader (Acts 18:27). Lydia also seems to be an important local leader (16:14-15) who provided hospitality to the missionaries (Acts 16:40-17:1). Phoebe is mentioned as a deaconess of the local community by the Apostle Paul. (Rom 16:1).Other early fathers address letters to local leaders. Polycarp was considered an important local leader that was even intentionally rooted out for martyrdom.[54]

These local leaders formed the backbone of the local worshipping community. They were often not trained but rather rose to the leadership position due to their piety. Many risked everything to lead the communities, having to flee underground to ensure the continuation of the faith. Others rose to the forefront and boldly led their community in the face of persecution. Sadly some fled and after the end of persecutions ended had to repent in order to be accepted back. Nonetheless, the local leaders could be people of money, power and influence and were often sought out when other missionaries came into the region. Their influence may have diminished as the rise of the hierarchical caste took their place, but they seem to have continued in other roles such as providing funding and protection for the local communities.

Harnack was convinced that the final group of the evangelists was the most abundant. They were the common people themselves. "The most numerous and successful missionaries of the Christian religion were not the professional teachers but Christians themselves, in virtue of their loyalty and courage."[55] These were the people who propagated the Faith, lived the life, formed the communities and raised their children in the Church. They were ardent and loyal followers of Christ. Time and again, the New

[54] *Polycarp*, chapters 5-7.
[55] Harnack, *Expansion*, 266-267.

Testament speaks of the followers of Christ who gave up all to be His disciples. This extended to the early apostles and the communities they established right through the time of persecution. It was the common person living a life of Faith that was the most powerful evangelist. Celsus in portraying these Christians gives a picture of the common person.

> "We see, indeed, in private houses workers in wool and leather, and fullers, and persons of the most uninstructed and rustic character, not venturing to utter a word in the presence of their elders and wiser masters; but when they get hold of the children privately, and certain women as ignorant as themselves, they pour forth wonderful statements, to the effect that they ought not to give heed to their father and to their teachers, but should obey them; that the former are foolish and stupid, and neither know nor can perform anything that is really good, being preoccupied with empty trifles; that *they* alone know how men ought to live, and that, if the children obey them, they will both be happy themselves, and will make their home happy also. And while thus speaking, if they see one of the instructors of youth approaching, or one of the more intelligent class, or even the father himself, the more timid among them become afraid, while the more forward incite the children to throw off the yoke, whispering that in the presence of father and teachers they neither will nor can explain to them any good thing, seeing they turn away with aversion from the silliness and stupidity of such persons as being altogether corrupt, and far advanced in wickedness, and such as would inflict punishment upon them; but that if they wish (to avail themselves of their aid) they must leave their father and their instructors, and go with the women and their playfellows to the women's apartments, or to the leather shop, or to the fuller's shop, that they may attain to perfection;— and by words like these they gain them over."[56]

It is clear that it was these simple Christians were evangelizing in the homes, in the community and even to those outside of the community. They raised their children in the Faith who turn carried the Church forward. Women most likely had a special place in that

[56] Origen, *Celsum*, book3 chapter 55.

they were specifically responsible for the raising of children. As Green defined it, they were "gossiping the Gospel."[57]

Yet, these people came from all classes. While the common perception was of simple Christians, Pliny the Younger wrote to the Emperor Trajan in abut 112 AD that "For many persons of every age, every rank, and also of both sexes are and will be endangered. For the contagion of this superstition has spread not only to the cities but also to the villages and farms."[58] So the early Christians were from both the villages and the cities, the rich and the poor, in fact from all sections of society. Clearly, Christianity spread quicker through cities since these were larger, more accessible and already had established populations though this does not discount the establishment of communities in the rural areas though that seemed to come later with the rise of monasticism.

In addition, Christianity also elevated the marginal castes such as women and slaves. All were given a new status under Christ as the Apostle Paul wrote, "There is neither Jew nor Gentile, there is neither slave nor free, there is neither male nor female; for you are all one in Jesus Christ." (Gal 3:28) This was significant in that it allowed participation in a greater scale then before. Women were permitted to participate, slaves were not marginalized and outsiders were welcome into the Christian community. This enabled the Church to grow because it was inclusive as long as one became part of the Body and lived in the way that Christ commanded. As Chadwick writes, "Christianity did not give political emancipation to either women or slaves, but it did much to elevate their domestic status by its doctrine that all men are created in God's image and all alike

[57] Green, *Evangelism*, 173.
[58] Pliny, *Trajan*, 4.

redeemed in Christ; and they must therefore be treated with sovereign respect."[59] These groups would provide a great number of converts to the Faith. They also brought along potential spouses because of the strict injuncture of marrying a Christian. While those already married were strongly admonished to remain married, the new marriage contracts had a stricter policy such as ensuring believers married each other and raise their progeny in the Faith. Thus, through mere demographics Christianity grew. People married, had children, and raised a family in the Faith. When whole households were converted, they included the slaves. These proved to be fertile grounds for evangelism.[60]

The Methods of Evangelism

There can be indentified from the New Testament and patristic records, six different ways that these groups evangelized. In fact, each of these groups utilized one or more of these methods. They provided a way for the Gospel message to be communicated but the message cannot be transmitted if it is not received. So they were just as powerful in how they were received by the people considering Christianity. These methods also seem to have continued through the time of Christ, into the apostolic period and the time of the legalization of Christianity. These methods include *kerygma* (proclamation), *didache* (teaching), *martyria* (witness), *apologia* (defense), *diaconia* (service), and *homologia* (confession).

The first method that can be identified is perhaps the most common, *kerygma*. Technically speaking, *kerygma* is translated "a heralding or announcing" but has come to

[59] Chadwick, *Early*, 59.
[60] For an example see the conversion of Cornelius and his household as recounted in Acts 10.

more popularly mean "preaching." The common usage in the New Testament and early patristic record was to be used in conjunction with the Gospel being preached.

The important aspect of *kerygma* is that it was a public act such as Jesus preaching in the marketplace or Apostle Paul speaking in Athens or the local leader sermonizing in the church. It was a common and effective manner of transmitting the gospel. "Preaching was, and has always been, a primary and necessary means of spreading the Gospel."[61] In fact, it was clear that the realm of preaching was not just limited to leaders and ministers but that all people were encouraged to preach the Gospel. Origen wrote, "All in whom Christ speaks, that is to say every upright man and preacher who speaks the word of God to bring men to salvation – and not merely the apostles and prophets – can be called an arrow of God."[62] So it was this public act of proclamation by all dedicated Christians which was often the first and most effective manner in which people received the message.

The next are is commonly combined together with *kerygma* and that is *didache* or "teaching." Sometimes the teaching was formal in a church or house setting led by a trained catechist. Other times, it accompanied the actual liturgical services themselves as part of the communal gathering. And even sometimes it was *ad hoc* wherever and in whatever situation evangelists found themselves. Justin Martyr wrote that, "and if anyone wished to come to me, I passed on to him the doctrines of truth."[63] It was clear that teaching and the passing on of the knowledge was critical in spreading the message.

[61] Crum, *Mission*, 82.
[62] Origen, *Commentary on Psalm 36*, 3:3 as translated by Green, *Evangelism*, 203.
[63] Justin, *Act of Martyrdom*, 1.2.

But as the church developed, so did the quality of teaching and the necessity of producing a more formal teaching atmosphere. There had already been a great tradition in the empire of teaching schools in Athens, Alexandria, and other major urban centers. While these were in the pagan philosophical tradition, they also produced some of the early Church's major theologians. By 190 AD, Pantaenus had established the great Catechetical School of Alexandria. This school, though in the classic tradition, became a major force in Church theology. Other schools would be established later, notable among them was the catechetical School in Antioch which provided its own theological approach. Nonetheless, the need for formal teaching and informal teaching continued to grow. The Church needed to constantly and consistently teach as new members were brought into the fold.

The next area is *martyria* or "witnessing." While this can translated as "bearing a testimony", perhaps the most enduring perception is the death of the Christians. While much has been written on this aspect of Christianity, it is important to state, in terms of evangelism, that martyrdom was not always eagerly sought as a method. But when it was placed upon a Christians, what they did with it was the critical evangelistic method. What the Christians did was to change martyrdom from an act meant to ridicule and shame the Christian community to something that became praiseworthy and triumphant. Tertullian compared those about to be martyred to warriors going into battle and through this battle, their courage would be a witness to the truth. They were to be careful as to how they witnessed in prison and be an agent of peace and harmony even as they faced death.

> "Give him not the success in his own kingdom of setting you at variance with each other, but let him find you armed and fortified with concord; for

> peace among you is battle with him. Some, not able to find this peace in the Church, have been used to seek it from the imprisoned martyrs. And so you ought to have it dwelling with you, and to cherish it, and to guard it, that you may be able perhaps to bestow it upon others."[64]

Thus, it was through their martyrdom that the Gospel was to be transmitted to others. The incredible challenge of witnessing the Faith through one's own death proved to be a powerful agent in transmitting the Gospel and those who were to go through such a trial were acutely conscious of their responsibilities. They were often encouraged and encouraging, such as Polycarp entreating his followers to not lose Faith so that their death was to be for a greater glory.

The next method of evangelism was *apologia* or "defense" of the Faith. As the growing Church became embroiled in more controversies, both from within and from the outside, the need to defend the Church became more acute. "The surviving literature does suggest, however, that missionary preaching evolved first into apologetic addresses and then into catechetical lecture-sermons."[65] It also become a method of evangelism because they exchange of letters clarified and explained the Christian Faith, putting in context with the world around them. "God intends to convert the mind as well as the heart and the body, and therefore *apologetic, argumentation, and dialogue* were important instruments in the early Church's missionary endeavors."[66] They also explained the Christian Faith in various ways so that other pagan groups could gain an understanding. "In similar fashion, Christian 'apologists' of the second century took up a missionary strategy that built upon parallels and commonalities they found in their faith and the pagan culture."[67] But mostly

[64] Tertullian, *Ad Martyres*, 1.
[65] Crum, *Mission*, 82.
[66] Weinrich, *Evangelism*, 73.
[67] Bryan Stone, *Evangelism After Christendom*. (Grand Rapids: Brazos, 2007) 234.

they defended the Faith from slander. For this reason, some of the great theological writings come from the early Church fathers defending the Church. The evangelism came through these incredible letters and writings which helped define and build the Faith through the coming centuries which would have its own controversies and challenges.

In *homologia*, or "confessing" there is another recognized evangelistic method in which the early Church utilized. By confessing what they perceived to be the truth, they were often put at odds with the world. But it was necessary to set a standard belief since there were so many different heretical beliefs emerging. While not always accepted immediately, standard confessions of Faith by evangelists established boundaries in which Christians could follow. With these boundaries, then could the evangelists have discussions with other groups considering Christianity. Justin Martyr wrote, "And more than all other men are we your helpers and allies in promoting peace, seeing that we hold this view, that it is alike impossible for the wicked, the covetous, the conspirator, and for the virtuous, to escape the notice of God, and that each man goes to everlasting punishment or salvation according to the value of his actions."[68] Confessing established those boundaries so that the leaders could assist those who were doing the work of the Church.

The final method was commonly demonstrated through the lifestyle of the Christian, a lifestyle dedicated to service or *diaconia*. It was the practical method that was often the most visible because it involved people caring for one another through some difficult and dangerous times. Tertullian wrote in his Apology in the 3rd century about how the pagans would marvel at the love the Christians showed. "Look, see how these Christians love

[68] Justin, A*pology,* chapter 12.

one another."[69] This service and love proved to be a powerful method of drawing people to the Church. People cared for one another, they loved one another and they served one another. They were a community that gathered around one another before God. In a time of trials, this was a powerful incentive.

That communal gathering around God served to be a powerful witness within the community. When people were sick, poor, widowed, the Church members assisted. The early Church documents even instruct the Christians to ensure they are caring for one another and established a position of deacon to ensure this was accomplished. The Didache points to this service explicitly as does just about every instructional document of the early Church. While this quote is outside of the timeframe being examined, St. John Chrysostom's exhortation on the two altars is illustrative of the diaconia both inside and outside the Church.

> "Would you see his altar?...This altar is composed of the very members of Christ, and the body of the Lord becomes an altar. This altar is more venerable even than the one which we now use. For it is…but a stone by nature; but become holy because it receives Christ's body: but that is holy because it is itself Christ's body…[which] you may see lying everywhere, in the alleys and in the marketplaces, and you may sacrifice upon it anytime…. When then you see a poor believer, believe that you are beholding an altar. When you see this one as a beggar, do not only refrain from insulting him, but actually give him honor, and if you witness someone else insulting him, stop him; prevent it."[70]

To serve was to be a Christian, and to be a Christian meant that one served. It was that simple and a powerful tool in evangelism.

[69] Tertullian, *Apology*, chapter 39.
[70] John Chrysostom, *Homily #20 on 2 Corinthians*, chapter 3.

While this list of methods can be greatly expanded with examples, it is clear that the methods of evangelism were not incredibly radical (with the exception of martyrdom). What they seemed to demonstrate that there were Christians in a community that preached, taught, served and witnessed to the truth that they had discovered. They were living as Jesus had commanded them by gathering together as a community and were presenting a life within that community to those around them. They would suffer persecutions and exile but they would also continue to preach and teach. While the Church would eventually legalized, centralized and even codified as it become part of the Empire, these early methods enabled that to occur. People grew the Church more then any other method.

Preparation and Reception

These people lived out their lives mostly in the local communities which feed them spiritually. The patristic sources helps one glean a picture of what was going on in the communities. For example, those records that do exist speak of different evangelists primarily preaching and teaching. Such was the way the Gospel message was transmitted. Those records do not necessarily record what was preached or taught but rather that they, in fact, preached and taught. This would keep in line with the thesis that there was not necessarily a strategy but rather a way of life. When the records do recount such preaching, they usually are theological points for clarity, explanations on lives for edification or even a record of actions. Such an example is the letters of Ignatius of Antioch as he travelled to Rome to be martyred. He was given the opportunity to preach

and teach, leaving seven letters to early Christian communities which expounded on theological and dogmatic themes.[71]

There are very few documents which actually explain the process of evangelism; perhaps lending credence to the theory that evangelism was simply "done." The author of the Didache writes about how to receive visitors to the community but not enquirers. Chapter Seven does briefly outline a baptismal formula which gives insight into what was being done with those being made ready for baptism.

> "And concerning baptism, baptize this way: Having first said all these things, baptize into the name of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Spirit, in living water. But if you have no living water, baptize into other water; and if you cannot do so in cold water, do so in warm. But if you have neither, pour out water three times upon the head into the name of Father and Son and Holy Spirit. But before the baptism let the baptizer fast, and the baptized, and whoever else can; but you shall order the baptized to fast one or two days before."[72]

But it really does not explain what the catechumen is supposed to do to be baptized. Justin Martyr mentions that baptism must be preceded by a period of fasting and prayer.

> "I will also relate the manner in which we dedicated ourselves to God when we had been made new through Christ; lest, if we omit this, we seem to be unfair in the explanation we are making. As many as are persuaded and believe that what we teach and say is true, and undertake to be able to live accordingly, are instructed to pray and to entreat God with fasting, for the remission of their sins that are past, we praying and fasting with them. Then they are brought by us where there is water, and are regenerated in the same manner in which we were ourselves regenerated. For, in the name of God, the Father and Lord of the universe, and of our Savior Jesus Christ, and of the Holy Spirit, they then receive the washing with water."[73]

[71] The seven letters were addressed to the Ephesians, Magnesians, Trallians, Romans, Philodelphians, Smyrnaeans, and to Polycarp. They date from the early 2nd century.
[72] *Didache*, chapter 7.
[73] Justin, *First Apology*. chapter 61.

Ireneaus in his Against Heresies writes of baptism being for those who already believe.[74] Tertullian's On Baptism is one of the first early Church documents which really outlines the instructions and theology of baptism. He warns against hasty baptisms, "If any understand the weighty import of baptism, they will fear its reception more than its delay: sound faith is secure of salvation"[75] and that there should be a period of preparation, "They who are about to enter baptism ought to pray with repeated prayers, fasts, and bending of the knee, and vigils all the night through, and with the confession of all by-gone sins, that they may express *the meaning* even of the baptism of John: They were baptized, says (the Scripture), confessing their own sins."[76] But again the instructions are lacking.

Origen also points to a series of testing and instruction for candidates. In addition, Cyprian believed that through baptism, a new and greater knowledge and insight would be gained.

> "But after that, by the help of the water of new birth, the stain of former years had been washed away, and a light from above, serene and pure, had been infused into my reconciled heart—after that, by the agency of the Spirit breathed from heaven, a second birth had restored me to a new man—then, in a wondrous manner, doubtful things at once began to assure themselves to me, hidden things to be revealed, dark things to be enlightened, what before had seemed difficult began to suggest a means of accomplishment, what had been thought impossible, to be capable of being achieved; so that I was enabled to acknowledge that what previously, being born of the flesh, had been living in the practice of sins, was of the earth earthly, but had now begun to be of God, and was animated by the Spirit of holiness."[77]

[74] Ireneaus, *Against Heresies*, 5.11.2.
[75] Tertullian, *On Baptism*, chapter 18.
[76] Tertullian, *On Baptism*, chapter 20.
[77] Cyprian, *Letter to Donatus*, chapter 4.

But the reality of these few documents demonstrated that the goal of any evangelism was baptism of the believer into the community. Clearly the methods, instructions and preparation may have been open to local customs or practices.

Hippolytes was really the first patristic writer to establish some clear direction on the preparation and reception of a catechumen. In his Apostolic Traditions, he outlines some major points. Before people were to be enrolled as a "hearer of the word", they would be brought before a teacher who examined their life and intentions as well ensure there were no impediments to be received.[78] Then, the catechumen spent at least three years as a "hearer of the word", even if that person was particularly zealous.[79] There would be a period of a developing prayer life and then they would be set aside for baptism.[80] Ultimately they would be prepared and baptized according to an established tradition.[81] However, their instruction would not end for Chapter Four is dedicated to instructions on continued prayer and learning the Faith after baptism.

It seems that by this time and going forward to Nicea, the Church had established a method of not only reaching out to people but also a process for bringing them into the Church. While they may not be much evidence of a strategy, there clearly is evidence of a process which included a long period of instruction, a formal reception as a catechumen, a formal method of both preparation for and the action of baptism, followed by continued growth in prayer and instruction. Furthermore, it is obvious that a developed theology that imparted this knowledge was being formed. This meant that as

[78] Hippolytus, *Apostolic Traditions*, book 2 chapter 16.
[79] Ibid, book 2, chapter 17.
[80] Ibid, book 2, chapter 18-19.
[81] Ibid, book 2, chapter 20-23.

the Church grew and encountered a more synchronistic society, it had to be more precise on what it was teaching and preaching. Finally, what was also clear was that there was a sacramental nature to all of this, whether being received into the Church, whether participating in a cycle of prayers, fasts, and feasts, including a central sacrament of the Eucharist, as well a continued growth in prayer life. Some of the early documents were quite precise on exactly how to conduct that prayer life, especially in preparing to commune.[82]

Thus, it could be reasonably argued that evangelism was again something that was done and lived rather than strategized and formulated. The early Church lived as Christians and brought others into that life as Christians. They followed a canon of faith that brought them into a greater relationship with the surrounding community. And they integrated those new people into the community by instruction, prayer and a sacramental life. They grew the Church because they themselves grew in the Faith. This proved to be the most powerful method of evangelism; sharing the Faith through one's own life.

Conclusion

This paper began with a question, how did the early Christians evangelize? What is clear that there was very little evangelistic strategy other then following the network of the Roman Empire. However, there was a strategy that the Gospel would not be contained within a small ethnic group but rather would reach out to the entire world. It was a hostile world yet one that was ripe for Christianity. As the Christian Church developed, it had to reexamine how the Gospel was presented, constantly re-presenting itself in

[82] For example see *Didache* or Hippolytus on specific instructions.

differing forms to differing people. This paper examined what the world was that they encountered, how they reacted to that world, who were the people that were involved in the spreading of the Gospel message and what was the process that developed. That process led to a greater understanding and defining of the sacramental activities which were critical in establishing and maintaining the Church. But in the end, there is very little evidence on the methodology. Rather, it seems that the early Church evangelized because that is what it was supposed to do. It was supposed to evangelize by its very nature of being the Church.

Furthermore, it is clear that the message was the method. The message of a Risen Christ, of a new life in that Risen Christ and a community that actualized His teachings really was how the Church spread. Thus, it was those people in that community, regardless of their station or position that were responsible in spreading the Gospel. They did so in many ways, martyrdom being the most radical but with the absolute and convicted knowledge that this was what they were called to accomplish. That it was in being a community serving and loving one another that the Good News was manifested. And it was natural that that Good News would recreate itself in other communities. "The final and most important element in the missionary work of the early Church was the utter conviction, the courage, the hopefulness and the practical concern for community, exhibited by those who professed and followed Christ. Their stance in and toward the Roman world was not an act which they put on *in order* to win converts, and hence it was not a conscious 'means' of spreading the Gospel. But, as an inseparable aspect of the Good News they proclaimed, their stance was *incidentally* the key to their impact."[83] The

[83] Crum, *Mission*, 84.

early Christians did so through living a life in relation with those around them. They lived that life with love and passion utilizing the gifts that the new Faith bestowed upon them. "It was then, with the Scriptures and prayers as their main weapons, backed up by their love, their burning zeal to share their faith with others, and the sheer quality of their living and dying that the early Christians set out to evangelize the world."[84]

But equally important was that they were not alone in this process. There were others who believed as they did and who provided the support network that would endure as the Christian Church. These networks were often manifested locally, in the churches or households, and enabled the faith to survive and be transmitted to the next generation. Ultimately it was the local community with the local people who grew the Church. "It grew because Christians constituted an intense community, able to generate the 'invincible obstinacy'…but yielded immense religious rewards."[85] These rewards were nothing less their perceived salvation. As recounted in 2 Clement, "if we do the will of our Father we shall belong to the spiritual Church, but if not, we shall fall under the Scripture which says 'My house became a den of brigands'. Let us therefore choose to belong to the Church of life so that we may win salvation."[86] The Church grew because salvation from the Risen Jesus Christ was the motivation. There was not a strategy but rather a people willing to live and love in the face of a world which rejected their life and their love and yet persevered. Maybe that is the lesson for the Christians of this age.

[84] Green, *Evangelism*, 235.
[85] Stark, *Rise*, 208.
[86] Clement, *2 Clement*, 14:1.

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